

In my family, my dad controlled the finances because he brought in the income. He dictated what was spent, when my mum could work and how they invested. The story I came to believe as a result was around power and control and how important it was to have control over the finances in a relationship. What I absolutely did not want was to be in the position of my mum, who never made any decisions over the finances and instead, for a long time, was told what she could spend and when she could work. Now, before you judge my dad too harshly, I want to acknowledge it was a different time. Today, even though I appreciate that's not a healthy position to have, it's a Money Story that a small part of me still holds true. So, while my husband, Tony, and I make large joint financial decisions together, I still have control over my personal finances, which includes owning a share portfolio in my own name, businesses in my own name and separate personal bank accounts. I often show Tony how my shares or businesses are performing so money isn't a secret between us, and we've also used the proceeds of my businesses or share portfolio at times for joint expenses or investments. But I feel safe because I have control over my finances and don't feel like I'm at the mercy of my partner.

If I didn't understand my Money Story, I suspect I might not be able to do money well with my husband. I'd be tempted to grab control and dictate how we behaved financially. Especially as I have a financial background, it would be so easy for me to justify to myself steamrolling over Tony with any financial decision-making. Instead, it's important to us that we work well together in all areas of our lives, including our finances. Yet again and again, Money Stories of power and control are something I see too many couples wrestling with.

Another Money Story I struggle with, like so many other women, is around the idea that I am somehow not enough. It's a belief that has a lot to do with my environment growing up—both my childhood and later my adult life experiences. The sum of these experiences led me to have an almighty victim mentality, where I believed it was okay, even expected, for me to only ever be financially mediocre. In my mind, my experiences gave me such a great excuse to be less than. If we looked at my nature, I'm highly competitive, to the point where if I don't feel I can win, I won't enter or try to compete. Ridiculous, I know, but that's me. Add that to what I perceived to be my many limitations and my victim mindset. I